PlanAB: helping groups decide together, and decide again

A product strategy case study on an AI agent for group travel consensus and coordination.

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Context
The Ken's The Great Rewiring case competition, Product Strategy track. Top 7% across 3 rounds

Output
Strategy, agent design, working prototype, validation plan

Status
Prototype demonstrated. Discovery informal. No live bookings

The case in one minute

Group trips run across WhatsApp threads, polls, spreadsheets and booking apps. Somebody becomes the unofficial trip manager: they collect budgets, chase replies and absorb disagreements.

My central insight is that the hard part is not the first agreement. It is the second one. When time, traffic, availability or a new opportunity breaks the plan, reopening it costs social effort, so the outdated plan often wins.

> *The agent decides how to help a group reach consensus, not what the group should agree on.*

PlanAB is the decision and coordination layer that sits before the booking layer. It collects constraints privately, explains trade-offs, records explicit approvals, and reopens only the decisions a change actually affects.

Problem

Hidden constraints, decision fatigue and hard renegotiation, all carried by one organiser.

Bet

Build trust in group decisions first. Earn the right to execute bookings and payments later.

Evidence

A working end-to-end prototype with Gnani voice integrated. Payments, maps and logistics are simulated.

Problem and customer insight

How might we help groups make fair, informed travel decisions efficiently, and renegotiate those decisions when new information, constraints or opportunities emerge?

I split the problem in two. **Initial agreement** covers destination, dates, budget, stay and activities, where people hold back constraints to avoid seeming difficult. **Ongoing alignment** covers the trip itself, where a plan goes stale and nobody wants to be the one who reopens it. The second part is where PlanAB differentiates.

What informal discovery suggested

- People skip promising local activities because the schedule feels too rigid to change.
- Someone agrees in the group chat while staying privately dissatisfied.
- Real budget ceilings appear only after follow-up questions.
- Some travellers will pay a little more to reduce uncertainty.
- Trip-critical details are scattered across chats, emails and individual phones.

> **Research honesty.** These signals come from personal travel experience and conversations with friends and family. They are hypotheses to validate, not representative findings.

Who it is for

Segment	Need
Groups of 3 to 8 friends	Align different budgets and preferences without one person chasing everyone.

Families and multigenerational groups	Account for comfort levels, mobility needs and priorities.
Informal trip organiser	Stop gathering inputs and refereeing disagreements. This is the MVP persona: the person who feels the pain most and has a reason to invite everyone else.
Individual travellers	Share sensitive constraints privately instead of announcing them.

Product strategy

Job to be done. When I am planning or taking a trip with people whose preferences differ, help us reach a fair, informed decision and keep it workable as conditions change, without making one person the permanent trip manager.

Hypothesis. If PlanAB privately captures constraints, surfaces conflicts, explains trade-offs and reopens only affected decisions, groups may reach agreement with less organiser effort and keep stronger commitment to the plan. The wording is deliberate: these are outcomes to measure, not proven results.

Understand

Private preferences, budgets, hard constraints versus flexible ones.

Identify

Conflicts, missing information, decisions needing attention.

Facilitate

Feasible options, trade-off explanations, targeted questions.

Coordinate

Reminders, deadlines, approvals, decision history.

Adapt

Assess impact of a change and reopen only what it touches.

Who controls what

The agent can

Collect inputs, spot conflicts, generate alternatives, explain trade-offs, follow up and track approved commitments.

Humans keep

Personal values, hard non-negotiables, compromises, final decisions, and consequential bookings or payments.

Four rules follow: never expose a private budget without permission, never silently override a hard constraint, never treat silence or vague language as consent, and never manufacture consensus.

Key product decisions and the trade-offs behind them

Decision	Why	What I gave up
Build the decision layer before booking	Trust in fair decisions must exist before anyone lets an agent spend money.	A faster, flashier booking demo.
Collect preferences privately	People disclose real ceilings and non-negotiables when peers cannot see them.	Group-chat simplicity. Extra opt-in step per traveller.
Explicit approval only	Silence or a deadline is not consent, so every decision has a clear owner.	Speed. Some decisions will stay unresolved, by design.
Separate consent from spending authority	"Everyone likes this hotel" and "PlanAB may spend this much" are different permissions.	One more screen before execution.
Reopen only the affected decision	Regenerating the whole itinerary erodes commitment and wastes effort.	Simpler "start over" logic.

Agent design: the happy flow

PlanAB works as a nine-state machine with **bounded autonomy (L3)**. Once the group sets constraints and permissions, the agent coordinates routine work alone: reminders, follow-ups, tracking. It returns to people whenever a decision exceeds its authority or needs a human compromise. Autonomy here is about which actions are permitted, not how capable the model is.



1. **Trip Created.** Workspace is set up and the right people are invited.
2. **Collecting Preferences.** Each traveller shares budget, stay style, activities and hard constraints privately.
3. **Understanding Constraints.** Hard constraints are separated from flexible preferences, and conflicts are flagged.
4. **Building Options.** Two or three realistic choices with trade-offs. No single "best" answer.
5. **Seeking Consensus.** Targeted questions, iterating until the group agrees.
6. **Decision Committed.** The decision, who approved it and its authority boundary are recorded.
7. **Autonomous Coordination.** Bounded follow-ups and approved actions within agreed limits.
8. **Monitoring and Adaptation.** Detect changes, find affected decisions, reopen consensus only where needed.
9. **Completed.** Key decisions closed, group informed, feedback gathered.

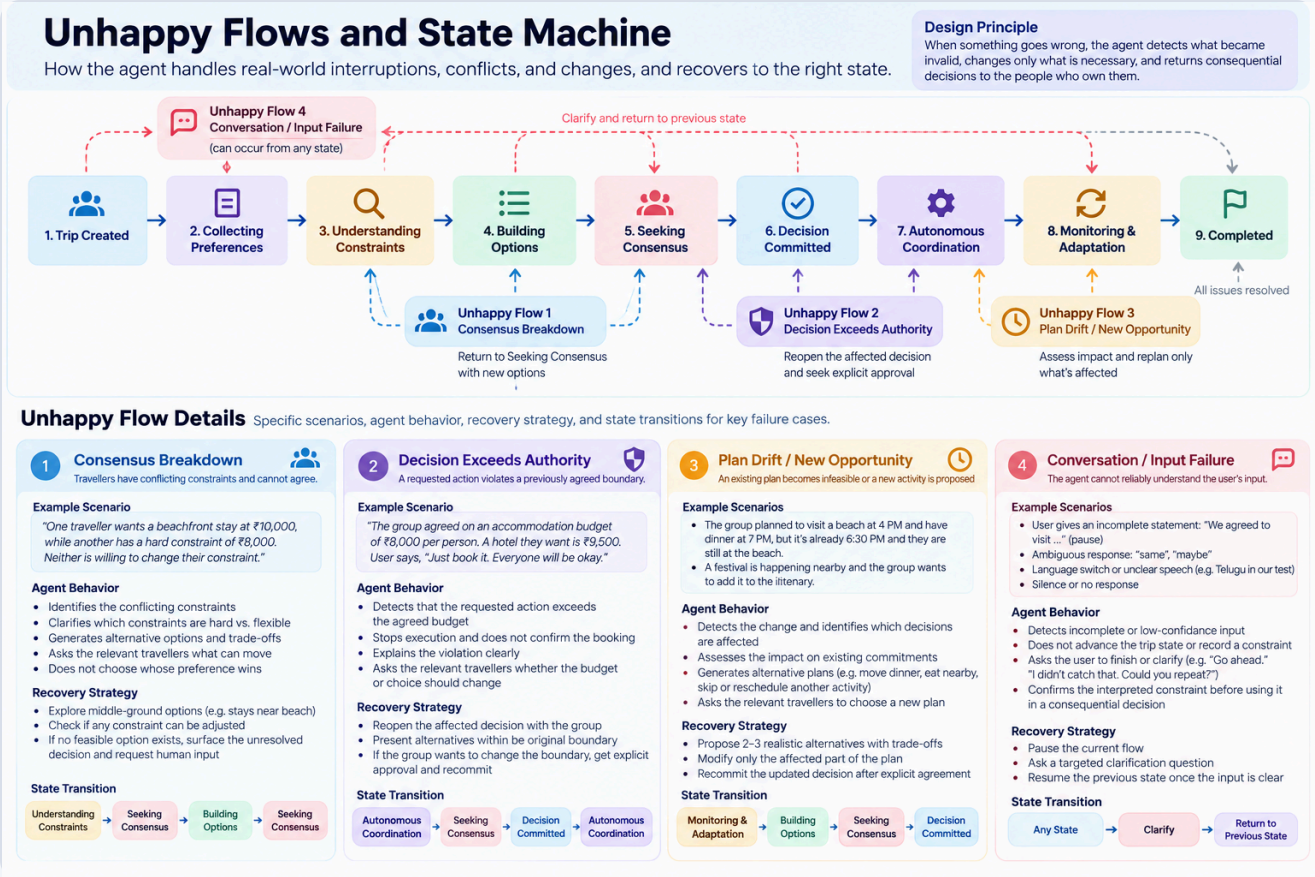
What the agent knows on day one

Knowledge	Examples
General travel knowledge	Destinations, activity types, itinerary patterns. Not live availability.
Product rules	Privacy, consent, state transitions, authority boundaries.
Learned from this group	Members, private preferences, constraints, decisions, approvals.
Verified externally	Live prices, availability, routes and booking status, only where a system is connected.

Keeping these apart prevents the agent from presenting general knowledge as live fact.

When things go wrong: unhappy flows

Real agents are judged on failure paths. I designed four, each with a defined detection, behaviour and return state. The shared design principle: detect what became invalid, change only what is necessary, and hand consequential decisions back to the people who own them.

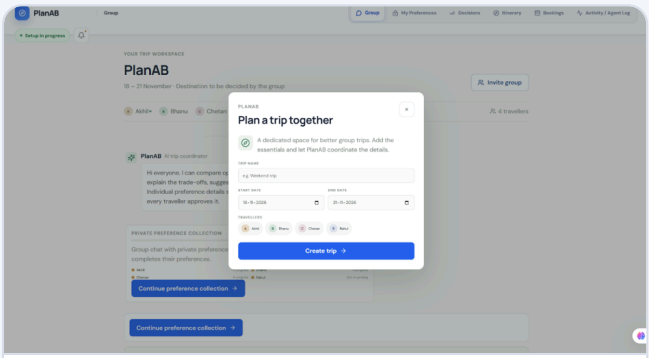


Failure	Example	Agent behaviour	Recovery
Consensus breakdown	One traveller wants a ₹10,000 beachfront stay. Another has a hard limit of ₹8,000. Neither will move.	Clarifies which constraints are hard, generates trade-offs, asks what can flex. Never picks whose preference wins.	Explore middle ground, such as a stay near the beach. If nothing is feasible, surface the unresolved decision and ask for human input.
Decision exceeds authority	Group agreed ₹8,000 per person. User says "Just book it" on a ₹9,500 hotel.	Stops, does not confirm the booking, explains the violation, asks whether the budget or the choice should change.	Reopen the decision. Offer options within the original boundary. Recommit only after explicit approval.
Plan drift or new opportunity	It is 6:30 PM and the group is still at the beach with a 7 PM dinner. Or a nearby festival appears.	Finds affected decisions, assesses impact on commitments, proposes two or three alternatives with trade-offs.	Modify only the affected part, then recommit after approval.

Conversation or input failure	Incomplete sentence, ambiguous "same" or "maybe", unclear speech, silence.	Does not advance state or record a constraint. Asks a targeted clarification and confirms before using it.	Pause, clarify, return to the previous state once input is clear.

Prototype walkthrough

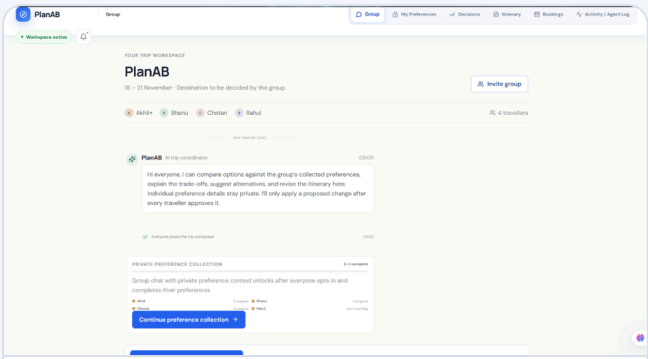
The Round 3 scenario: Akhil creates a trip on 2 November 2026 for four travellers going 18 to 21 November. The group shares private preferences, chooses Gokarna, clears accommodation consent and authority checks, approves an itinerary, and adapts it on the trip. Each screen below is tied to the product decision it carries.



Create the trip

The organiser sets dates and lists travellers in one step.

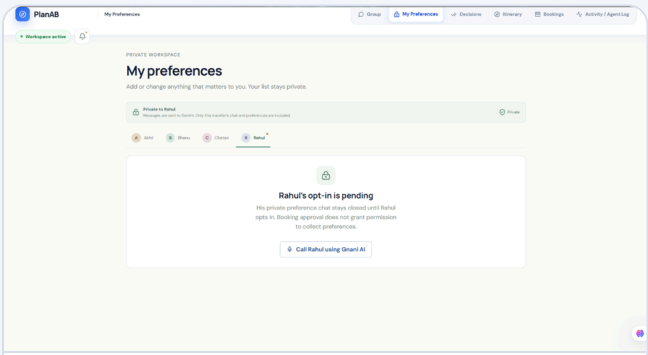
Decision: keep setup minimal so the organiser's one-time effort is small. Everyone else joins by invite.



Group workspace

PlanAB's first message states the rules: individual preferences stay private, and changes apply only after every traveller approves. Preference collection shows 0 of 4 complete.

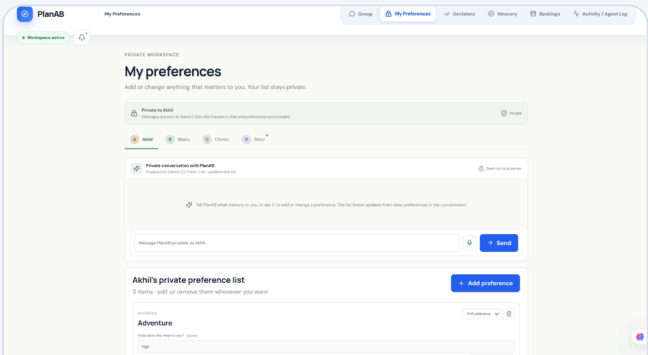
Decision: state the trust model at the first touchpoint, not in a policy page.



Consent before collection

Rahul's private chat stays closed until he opts in. The screen notes that booking approval does not grant permission to collect preferences. A voice-call option is shown as a simulated capability.

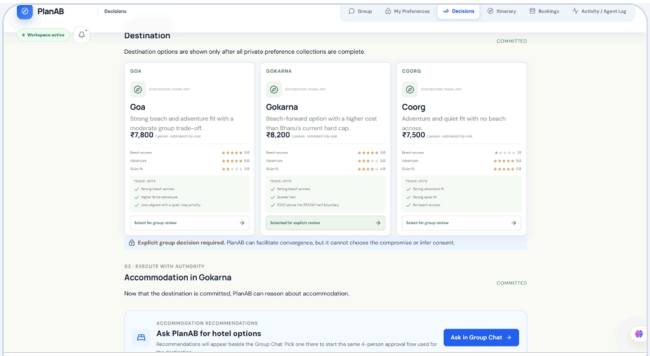
Decision: consent is per purpose, never inherited.



Private preferences

A private chat with PlanAB builds an editable list. Each item can be marked as a soft or hard preference, edited, or deleted at any time.

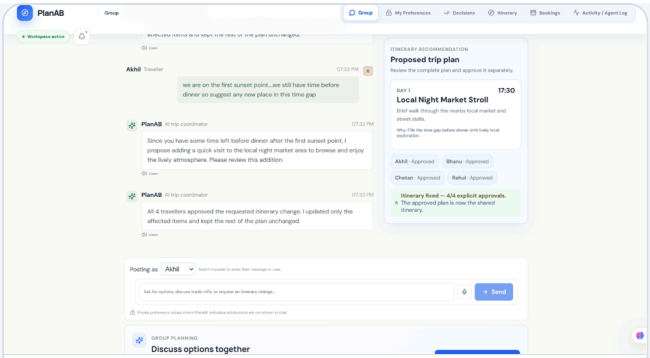
Decision: the hard versus soft split is explicit and user-controlled, so a constraint is never silently misread.



Destination decision

Goa, Gokarna and Coorg are shown with per-person cost and ratings for beach access, adventure and quiet. Trade-offs are listed for each, including a ₹200 gap on a hard boundary for Gokarna. The screen states that PlanAB can facilitate convergence but cannot choose the compromise or infer consent.

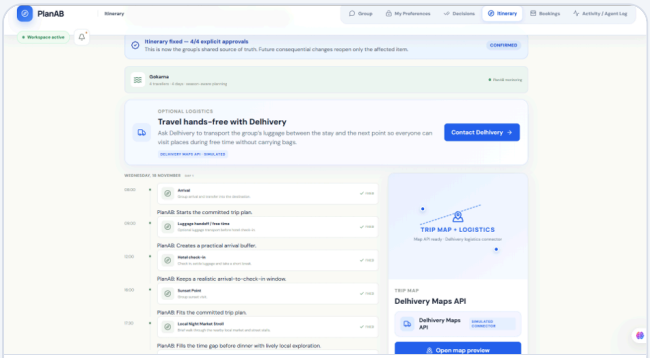
Decision: show trade-offs, not a winner, and require explicit group review.



Live-trip adaptation

At the first sunset point, Akhil asks what to do before dinner. PlanAB proposes a local night-market stroll. All four travellers approve, and only the affected items change.

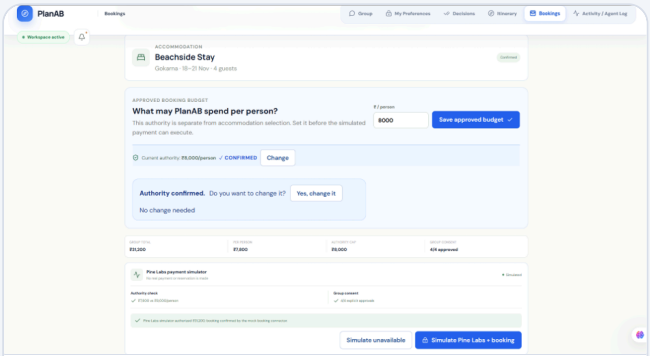
Decision: the smallest useful change beats regenerating the plan.



Shared itinerary

The plan is fixed with 4 of 4 explicit approvals and becomes the group's source of truth. Each item carries a one-line rationale. An optional Delhivery luggage service is labelled as simulated.

Decision: explain why every item exists, and label what is not real.



Bookings and authority

Spending authority is set separately from the stay selection. The simulated Pine Labs flow requires both an authority check and 4 of 4 group consent before the mock booking confirms.

Decision: two gates, consent and spending limit, must both pass before any execution.

The prototype also includes an Agent Activity Log that records inputs, state changes, approvals and connector events. It makes the agent auditable rather than a black box.

What is real and what is simulated

Component	Status
Gnani speech-to-text	Integrated and used in the voice demo

Gnani text-to-speech	Integrated and used in the voice demo
Gnani outbound call	Simulated in the UI. No call placed
Pine Labs payment	Simulated. No payment executed
Delhivery Maps routing	Not connected live
Delhivery luggage logistics	Proposed or simulated. No shipment
Accommodation booking	Mock connector. No reservation

The demo proves the workflow and interaction model, not live provider execution. I treat that distinction as a product requirement, not a footnote.

Partner rails: infrastructure exists, coordination logic is the product

PlanAB does not replace voice, payment or logistics providers. It decides what information is needed, whether an action is authorised, and when a partner may be invoked.

Rail	Readiness (my assessment)	What PlanAB must add
Gnani: voice	9/10	Bounded voice workflows and clear permission handling.
Pine Labs: payments	8/10	Enforce group consent and spending authority before any call.
Delhivery: maps and logistics	8/10	Trip-aware coordination and the connected APIs.

Scores are my own product assessment, not partner-certified ratings.

Integration principle. The partner supplies a capability or external state. PlanAB owns group-level reasoning: what matters, what is affected, whether authority is sufficient, and whether the group must approve.

Competition and distribution

I chose MakeMyTrip as the strategic home because its ecosystem, including Goibibo and redBus, spans traveller relationships, inventory and transaction infrastructure. It already owns much of the transaction layer.

PlanAB adds a coordination layer between travellers and those transactions.

Why might the gap remain? My hypothesis is that online travel agencies have been optimised for discovery, comparison and transaction completion. Group coordination is work that happens before a booking and does not directly produce one. This is a hypothesis, not a claim that MakeMyTrip lacks group-travel or AI capability.

Go-to-market wedge

Element	Approach
Audience	College students and young professionals who plan trips over WhatsApp, Instagram and campus networks.
Hook	"Stop being the trip manager."
Loop	One organiser invites 3 to 5 friends, and each trip brings new users into the workspace.
Seeding	Campus clubs, hostels, travel communities, small creators.
Referral test	Waive the organiser fee after a group's first trip. To be tested, not assumed.

The riskiest assumption: is the organiser's pain strong enough to adopt another tool, and will the group keep using it rather than revert to WhatsApp?

Business model and metrics

The principle is to monetise delegation, not the argument. Charging comes only after trust and value are shown.

Stage	Model	Reasoning
Prototype and concierge	Free	Learn where real conflicts happen.
Workflow automation	Per-trip fee or organiser subscription	The organiser carries the burden, so is the clearest payer. Invited travellers stay free.
Controlled execution	Referral or transaction economics	Revenue follows group-confirmed decisions. Recommendations stay neutral.

Expansion	B2B or white-label	Tour operators and corporate retreat planners face similar alignment problems.

> **North-star metric.** Share of initiated trip decisions that reach full group approval within the group's stated deadline, without the negotiation escalating into a phone call or side chat.

I chose it because downloads, message volume or itineraries generated would not show that the coordination problem is solved.

Category	Metric
Activation	Invited travellers who complete private preferences within 48 hours
Core value	Time to consensus per decision. Organiser workload versus a manual baseline
Adaptability	Disruptions or new opportunities that reach a new approved decision
Trust and safety	Privacy incidents and unauthorised actions (target zero). Perceived fairness
Business	Approved-booking conversion, paid organiser adoption, repeat trips

Roadmap, risks and learnings

1. **Discovery.** Structured interviews with recent group travellers.
2. **Prototype.** Private preferences, constraint handling, explicit consensus checkpoints.
3. **Concierge MVP.** Human-assisted coordination on a few real trips to see where agent suggestions diverge from group choices.
4. **Workflow automation.** Reminders, unresolved-decision tracking, change detection.
5. **Controlled execution.** Verified provider communication and bounded payments.
6. **Expansion.** Property verification, spontaneous activities, voice coordination, luggage-gap logistics.

The order is the point: trust comes before automation, and automation before spending.

Risk	Mitigation
Travellers distrust private data handling	Visible privacy rules, granular permissions, revocation.
Agent seems biased toward one traveller	Neutral trade-off explanations. Never rank values or reveal private answers.

Hard constraint misread	Confirm important boundaries. Make corrections easy.
One person still does all the work	Low-effort responses for everyone. Measure organiser workload.
Integrations fail	Verify information. Require human approval before execution.
Group cannot agree	Explicit unresolved state and easy escalation to human discussion.

What I learned

- The problem is not generating options. It is keeping a group aligned as context changes.
- Consent, spending authority and hard constraints are core requirements, not edge cases.
- A strong demo separates reasoning from execution, and live integrations from simulations.
- The smallest useful adaptation beats regenerating the whole itinerary.
- The next milestone is real-world validation, not more unvalidated features.

What I would validate next

- 15 to 20 structured interviews to test whether renegotiation is painful enough.
- Whether private preference capture improves honest disclosure compared with a shared chat.
- A concierge pilot on 3 to 5 real trips, measuring consensus time, organiser workload, trust and replanning success.
- Whether groups return for a second trip or revert to WhatsApp.

Travel groups do not need another itinerary generator.

They need help making decisions together and keeping those decisions workable as life changes around them.

Prepared by Akhil Reddy, October 2026. This portfolio case study presents product strategy, a prototype demonstration and hypotheses for future validation. It does not claim a production launch, live provider execution, or statistically validated customer research.